FEATURES OF KYOTO PROTOCOL, 1997

The final shape to the Kyoto Protocol could be given after much bargaining and adjustments. It was adopted on 11 December, 1997. The main features of the Kyoto Protocol are as follows:

1. Under the Protocol, 37 countries ("Annex I countries") commit themselves to a reduction of four greenhouse gases (GHG) (carbon dioxide, methane, nitrous oxide, sulphur hexafluoride) and two groups of gases (hydrofluorocarbons and perfluorocarbons) produced by them, and all member countries give general commitments. Annex I countries agreed to reduce their collective greenhouse gas emissions by 5.2% relative to levels prevailing in 1990.
2. Most non-Annex I Parties belonged to the low-income group, with a very few classified as middle-income. They are not obligated by the limits of emissions in the Kyoto Protocol. Fast growing economy countries like China, South Africa, India and Brazil are still in this non-obligated group.
3. The agreement aims to lower overall emissions from a group of six greenhouse gases by 2008–12. Cuts in the three most important gases – carbon dioxide (CO_2), methane (CH_4), and nitrous oxide (N_2O) and cuts in three long-lived industrial gases – hydrofluorocarbons (HFCs), perfluorocarbons (PFCs), and sulphur hexafluoride (SF_6) were agreed upon.
4. The commitment period was to be from 2008–12.
5. Inclusion among cuts of sources and removal of defined 'sinks' or carbon absorbent material was limited to aforestation, reforestation and deforestation since 1990.
6. Clean Development Mechanism (CDM), emissions trading and joint projects implementation were agreed upon towards fulfilling emission cuts which came to be identified as 'voluntary' commitments of non-Annex 1 or developing countries.
7. Absence of any mechanism to ensure compliance or punitive measures for non-compliance.

The Kyoto Protocol was about to expire at the end of 2012 but it was extended at the UN Climate Change Conference which was held at